public to know the difference. When I ask him how bestiality fits into this view, he claims it was a subliminal ‘warning to the public’ to not indulge in ‘dirty things’! A blander third story is that the temples variously depict the four aims of life: *artha*, kama, dharma, moksha. But the guides simply regurgitate these words, failing to explain why depictions of kama had to be so explicit, rather than figurative.

Sadly, the ignorance peddled by the guides goes even further. For example, when Burt ‘rediscovered’ these temples, many had been badly damaged by vandals, lightening, trees and age-related decay (considerable restoration work has since been undertaken). Yet one guide blames the damaged state of the temples on Aurangzeb! Never mind that the temples already lay deeply buried in the jungle by Aurangzeb’s time. When I point this out, he seeks to correct me: ‘No, no, Sirji! The temples were *active* then!’ Most guides seem to also make things up as they go along, confidently expounding on sculptural scenes about which even scholars are divided or silent. No self-respecting guide here ever says, ‘I’m not sure.’

After talking to several guides one afternoon, I amble through town to the eastern group of temples, from where I can see the low, white-edged Dantla Hills, so named for resembling the worn-out teeth (*danth*) of old men. These hills and Khajuraho lie atop the Bundelkhand gneiss, the oldest rock bed in India. It is early February; the days are getting longer and warmer and the air less polluted. At night the moon isn’t orange-yellow but white, and the sky has far more stars than I ever see in Delhi NCR.

A local boy soon falls in step with me, a self-appointed guide angling for a tip. He points out two flowering trees: flame of the forest, with bright orange-red flowers used in temple rituals, and mahua, whose flowers taste like figs when dried and make a potent hooch when fermented. Even animals are said to be drawn to the fragrance of its rotting flowers, and funny stories of drunk animals, such as deer, monkeys, bears and elephants appear in local folk tales.[11]

During dinner I think again of my encounter with the guides. I feel a rush of anger at first, then of sadness, at all the hokum they spread and their lack of intellectual curiosity and reasoning skills. Back in the room, my mind drifts to the larger malaise in Indian education, its deficits of critical thinking and historical imagination, until I fall asleep listening to a wedding